

MIG-1

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-1

Age: 34

Gender: Female

Country of origin: Nigeria

Host country: Germany

Years in host country: 6

Occupation: Nurse

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I came to Germany six years ago after completing my nursing degree in Lagos. My homeland was facing severe economic instability at the time, with rising unemployment and a currency that kept losing its value, and I wanted to build a safer and more predictable future for my children. It was an extraordinarily difficult decision to leave behind everything familiar, my extended family, my language, the streets I had grown up on, but I saw far greater opportunity here in the European healthcare sector, which was actively recruiting trained nurses. I arrived alone at first, secured my footing, and then brought my family over once I had a stable contract and somewhere decent to live. The first winter nearly broke my resolve, both because of the cold and the loneliness, but I reminded myself daily why I had made the journey.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion, to me, means being seen as a full human being, not merely as a foreigner who happens to be filling a labour shortage that the local population cannot or will not fill. It is the difference between being tolerated and being genuinely welcomed. It shows itself in small but powerful ways: when my colleagues invite me to their homes for dinner, when my accent is met with patience rather than visible irritation, when my professional opinion is sought and respected in clinical decisions, and when I feel that I truly belong to this society rather than simply existing within its borders. Inclusion is not charity and it is not pity; it is the recognition that I bring value and that my presence enriches rather than diminishes the community around me.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: Yes, unfortunately, I have experienced xenophobia on more than one occasion. In my very first year, a patient flatly refused to be treated by me because of the colour of my skin, telling the ward staff that he did not want a foreigner touching him. It was profoundly humiliating, especially because I was fully qualified and entirely capable of providing the care he needed, arguably more experienced than some of the staff he would have preferred. My supervisor supported me firmly and reassigned the situation appropriately, which mattered a great deal, but the memory of that rejection still stings deeply years

later. There have been other, subtler incidents too, comments disguised as jokes, assumptions that I must be a cleaner rather than a nurse, that accumulate quietly over time.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: The language barrier was my greatest obstacle in the beginning. Medical German is extraordinarily technical, full of compound words and precise terminology, and even after years of dedicated study I still sometimes struggle with regional dialects and the rapid, colloquial way people speak outside the hospital. Beyond language, the bureaucracy was genuinely overwhelming. The process of validating my foreign nursing credentials took nearly two years of paperwork, translations, certified copies, and waiting for offices to respond, during which I could not work at the level I was trained for. There was also the emotional challenge of isolation, of being far from the support network of aunts, cousins and friends who would ordinarily help raise children and share burdens.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: My workplace has been surprisingly welcoming overall, more so than I had feared before arriving. The hospital runs diversity and anti-discrimination training, and the majority of my German colleagues treat me as a genuine equal, consult me, and trust my judgement. There are, inevitably, a few individuals who remain cold and distant, who never quite meet my eye or include me in casual conversation, but I have learned over time to direct my energy toward those who show genuine respect and warmth rather than exhausting myself trying to win over people who have already decided how they feel. The work itself, caring for patients, gives me purpose and a sense of dignity that transcends the occasional unpleasantness.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I maintain my Nigerian identity through cooking traditional meals like jollof rice and egusi soup, through speaking Igbo with my children at home so they do not lose the language of their grandparents, and through celebrating our cultural and religious festivals with the small but tight-knit Nigerian community here. At the same time, I have genuinely embraced certain German values that I admire, such as punctuality, directness in communication, and respect for rules and order. I feel that I live between two worlds, and while this is sometimes exhausting, requiring me to constantly translate not just words but cultural expectations, it is also profoundly enriching. My children are growing up with two heritages, and I want them to feel that both belong to them fully.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: The media often portrays African migrants as either helpless victims fleeing catastrophe or as economic burdens straining the welfare system. This one-dimensional and frankly lazy narrative shapes how ordinary Germans perceive me before they have even learned my name or exchanged a single word with me. I wish journalists would show the fuller reality: the doctors, engineers, nurses, teachers, and entrepreneurs who contribute enormously to this country's economy and society every single day. When the only stories told about people who look like me are stories of desperation or crime, it is no wonder that some people approach me with suspicion or condescension rather than curiosity and openness.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: Local integration programmes helped me tremendously, particularly in the early years. I attended free language courses that gave me the foundation I needed, and I participated in a mentorship programme that paired me with an experienced German nurse who guided me through both the professional and the everyday cultural aspects of life here. However, these programmes need considerably more funding and greater cultural sensitivity to reach their full potential. Sometimes the instructors did not understand the specific challenges that African women in particular face, the intersection of race, gender and migration status, and the courses were often designed with a generic migrant in mind rather than recognising the very different circumstances people arrive from.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: My children have adapted far more easily than I have, as children usually do. They speak flawless, accent-free German and have close German friends, which sometimes creates a subtle gap between us, moments where they navigate this culture more instinctively than I ever will. I occasionally worry that they might lose their connection to their Nigerian heritage, that the pull of fitting in will gradually erode the language and traditions I am trying to preserve. But I am also deeply proud that they move through this society with a confidence and ease that I never had at their age, that they see themselves as belonging here by right. My task is to make sure they carry both identities forward without shame.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To reduce xenophobia, I firmly believe education must start early, in schools. Children should learn about migration, about colonial history and its lasting consequences, and about the real contributions that immigrants have made to their society. But beyond formal education, personal contact matters most of all. In my experience, when local people actually befriend a migrant, share a meal, work alongside them, come to know them as an individual with a family and hopes and fears, their prejudices tend to dissolve almost naturally. Fear thrives in ignorance and isolation; it withers in the presence of genuine human relationship. Policy matters too, of course, but no policy can substitute for the simple experience of knowing someone different from yourself.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: My hope is to eventually open a healthcare clinic that serves both migrants and locals, a place that bridges communities through the universal experience of needing and receiving care. I want to prove, through concrete action rather than argument, that immigrants do not simply take from society; we give, and we give abundantly. On a more personal level, I dream of being able to visit Nigeria more often to see my ageing parents and the relatives I left behind, without any fear of jeopardising my residency status here. And above all, I hope to see my children flourish, secure in who they are, achieving things that would not have been possible in the country I left.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice to new migrants is to be patient with yourself and persistent with the system. Learn the language as quickly and as thoroughly as you possibly can, because it is the single key that opens every other door, professional, social and personal. Find your community, the people who share your background and understand your journey, because they will sustain you emotionally, but do not allow yourself to become isolated entirely within that community, because integration requires reaching

outward too. Expect the process to take years rather than months, and do not be discouraged by setbacks. And most importantly, never let anyone's prejudice make you doubt your own worth, your dignity, or your right to build a good life here.